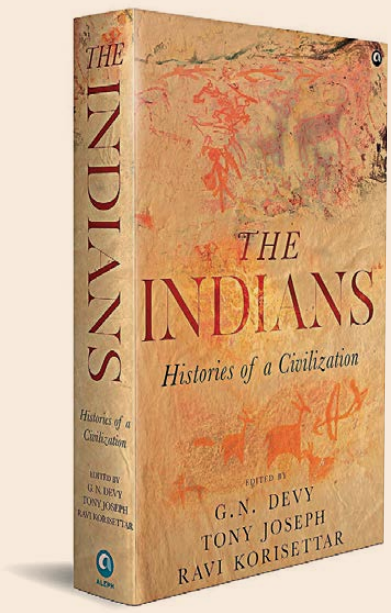
Who were the first Indians to inhabit the subcontinent? Scholar, linguist and cultural activist G.N. Devy has no time for this question. "There is no merit in it," he says. "Because genetics tells us all of us are a mixed population. It's very difficult to decide who's the original, who is the purest. It's a completely futile exercise in the 21st century."

Devy, a retired professor, best known for leading the People's Linguistic Survey of India, has most recently co-edited *The Indians: Histories of a Civilization*. The ambitious volume, spanning 12,000 years up until 2000, includes essays from over 100 scholars and touches on varied aspects of the country's past. The other editors are journalist and writer Tony Joseph and archaeologist Ravi Korisettar.

"The genesis of this book lies in the contestation unfolding before us in recent years between the scientific view of history and the ideologically charged attempts to distort the history of South Asia," Devy writes in the introduction. He refers to recent committees set up by the government that proposed to study the origin and evolution of Indian culture.




**THE INDIANS**
**Histories of a Civilization**
*Edited by G.N. Devy, Tony Joseph and Ravi Korisettar*
ALEPH
**₹1,299; 648** pages

**THE INDIANS, SPANNING 12,000 YEARS UP UNTIL 2000, INCLUDES ESSAYS FROM OVER 100 SCHOLARS AND TOUCHES ON VARIED ASPECTS OF INDIA'S PAST**

BOOKS

# *Singing in the Dark Times*

**Amit Chaudhuri's *On Being Indian* raises questions on the nature of the contemporary intellectual and rationalism's role in religious discourse**

Novelist, poet, essayist and musician Amit Chaudhuri is a man of few words, but he chooses them with care. This slim volume—its main text runs to just 71 pages with generous use of white space—is a dense distillation of his thoughts, in this case on India's current sociopolitical environment. And he doesn't pull his punches.

*On Being Indian* had its origins in a Parisian apartment, where Chaudhuri lived for several months in 2018-19 while his daughter worked on her two final-year college theses. The subject of one of these was the 'organic intellectual'. That's how Chaudhuri first encountered the term coined by Antonio Gramsci in his *Prison Notebooks*, although the Marxist thinker did little to delineate it.

While the book takes off from the anti-CAA protests that swept the country just before the pandemic—and of which it is also a concise chronicle—it goes on to more cerebral matters. Chiefly, it grapples with a question that has been in the national consciousness (since 2014, by Chaudhuri's reckoning): what it means to be Indian, especially an intellectual, in the current milieu. Chaudhuri makes a distinction between the traditional intellectual—who appears to transcend class—and the 'organic intellectual', who "*is* defined by class, by the economy, by profession...and by their work." He cites